MODULE 15 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Reporting, transparency and feedback

Understanding reporting requirements, building reports people can act on, honest status, supporting governance, and reporting agile work upward.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 15 of 49

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A good report helps someone **decide or act**. Everything else is noise.

Understanding reporting requirements

- **Who** receives it, and **what decisions** do they make with it?
- **Governance cadence**: steering meetings, phase gates, portfolio reviews.
- **Mandatory** reporting: contracts, regulators, funding bodies, with their required formats.
- **Organisational standards**: PMO templates and definitions, which are process assets.
- Agree all of this early, and record it in the communications plan.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Some reporting is optional and tailorable. Contractual and regulatory reporting is not.

Kinds of project report

REPORT	ANSWERS
Status	Where are we now against the plan?
Progress	What has been completed since the last report?
Forecast	Where are we heading, on time, cost and scope?
Variance or exception	What is outside agreed tolerance, and what are we doing about it?
Trend	Is performance improving or getting worse over time?
Gate or milestone	Are we ready to proceed to the next phase?

ON THE EXAM

Status without a forecast only tells people where you were. Decision-makers need where you are heading.

Full status or management by exception?

FULL STATUS

Everything, every time

- Every workstream, every metric
- Long, and read by few
- Important items easily buried
- Fits teams and detail-focused audiences

MANAGEMENT BY EXCEPTION

Only what needs attention

- Items outside agreed tolerance
- Decisions required, with options
- Short, and read by the right people
- Fits sponsors and steering committees

THE TIEBREAKER

Agree the tolerances first. Then senior stakeholders see only what breaches them, plus decisions needed.

RAG status that tells the truth

- Define red, amber and green with **agreed, objective thresholds**, not personal judgement.
- **Watermelon reporting**: green on the outside, red on the inside. Problems hidden until they explode.
- Make amber **safe** to report. An early amber is a gift; a late red is a crisis.
- Always pair a colour with the **reason** and the **action**.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If people are punished for amber, you will only ever see green, until you see red.

Tailoring reports to the audience

- **Sponsor and steering committee**: one page, trends, exceptions, risks, and decisions needed.
- **Team**: detailed progress, blockers, what is next.
- **Regulators and funders**: exactly the format and timing they require.
- Keep detail **available on request**, so a short report never hides anything.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The outline asks for reports aligned with sponsor and stakeholder expectations. One report rarely fits all.

Honest reporting

- Report the **real** status, including forecasts that are uncomfortable.
- Omitting a known forecast overrun misleads as much as a false number does.
- If someone asks you to change or leave out information, talk to them first, then report accurately.
- Honesty is one of the four values in PMI's Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Accurate is not negotiable. How you present bad news, with context and options, is where the skill lies.

Supporting governance

- The outline asks you to **support reporting and governance processes**.
- For a **phase gate**: evidence against the exit criteria, risks, the forecast, and a recommendation.
- For a **decision request**: the question, options with impacts, a recommendation, and the deadline.
- For an **escalation**: what threshold was breached, what has been tried, and what is needed.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Governance bodies decide. Your job is to make their decision easy, well-informed and on time.

Reporting agile work upward

- **Sprint reviews** are the best report: stakeholders see working results.
- **Burnup charts and release forecasts** show progress towards a goal, and when it is likely.
- Report **outcomes and value** delivered, not just the number of items done.
- Never compare teams by **velocity**. Story points are relative within one team.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Translate agile progress into forecasts and outcomes for governance. Do not turn velocity into a league table.

Data, dashboards and AI

- **Automated dashboards** from the team's own tools reduce effort and errors.
- One **source of truth**, so different reports never show different numbers.
- Generative AI can draft summaries from updates, which saves time.
- But **verify** anything AI produces against the source before sending. You remain accountable.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Tools can gather and draft. Only the project manager can be accountable for what the report says.

Is anyone using your reports?

- Ask recipients what they use, what they skip, and what they wish they had.
- Watch for signals: decisions made without the report, questions it should have answered.
- Remove what nobody uses. Shorter reports get read.
- This is the feedback loop from module fourteen, applied to reports.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A report nobody uses is cost without value. Ask, then cut or change it.

Project Lantern: the steering committee page

- **Top**: overall forecast for go-live and budget, with a trend arrow.
- **Middle**: exceptions only, with the threshold breached and the action under way.
- **Bottom**: decisions needed, with options and a recommendation.
- Links to the live dashboard and the app's latest sprint review recording.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> One page: forecast, exceptions, decisions. Detail one click away.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Everything was green, then suddenly red	Objective thresholds; make amber safe to report
Sponsor cannot use a long report	One-page exception summary; detail on request
A phase gate is coming	Evidence against criteria, risks, forecast, recommendation
PMO wants to compare team velocities	Explain why not; offer forecasts and outcomes
Asked to leave out an uncomfortable forecast	Discuss, then report accurately
AI-drafted report contained an error	Verify against the source; correct it openly

ON THE EXAM

Reports exist to support decisions. Make them honest, tailored and easy to act on.

> For five months, every workstream on a programme reported green. This month, one lead reports that go-live will be missed by two months.
>
> It emerges that the team had known about the problem for weeks, but did not want to be the first to report amber.

What should the project manager do to prevent this happening again?

A Require every workstream to report amber until proven otherwise.

B Formally reprimand the lead who delayed the bad news.

C Agree objective status thresholds, and make it clear that early amber is welcomed, not punished.

D Stop using colour ratings in status reports.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do to prevent this happening again?

A Default to amber.

Makes the colours meaningless in the other direction.

B Reprimand the lead.

Confirms the fear that caused the silence. Next time, even later.

C Objective thresholds; welcome early amber.

Removes judgement from the colours, and removes the fear behind the delay.

D Drop colour ratings.

The colours were not the problem. The fear of reporting was.

THE SIGNAL

Watermelon reporting has two causes: subjective colours and fear. Fix both.

> The sponsor tells the project manager that the fifteen-page monthly status report is too long to read before steering meetings.
>
> She says she often only discovers important issues during the meeting itself.

What should the project manager do?

A Provide a one-page summary of forecasts, exceptions, risks and decisions needed, with detail available on request.

B Keep the full report, because it contains everything she needs.

C Add an appendix with more detail on the main issues.

D Send the full report weekly instead of monthly, so each one is shorter.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A One-page exception summary; detail on request.

Aligned with how she actually uses reports: fast, decision-focused.

B Keep it as it is.

Everything is in it, and she still misses the important items.

C Add an appendix.

Makes a report that is too long even longer.

D Send it weekly.

The same volume, delivered four times as often.

THE SIGNAL

The sponsor misses important items in a long report: tailor it, by exception, to her decisions.

> A project reaches the end of its design phase. The steering committee must decide at the phase gate whether to approve moving into construction.
>
> The project manager is preparing for the gate review.

What should the project manager present?

A. A demonstration of the design model, to show the progress made.

B. The full detailed schedule for the construction phase.

C. A brief email summary after the meeting.

D. Evidence against the gate criteria, risks, the forecast, and a recommendation with the decision requested.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager present?

A. A design demonstration.
Useful context, but it does not show whether the gate criteria are met.

B. The full construction schedule.
Detail for the team, not a basis for a go or no-go decision.

C. An email afterwards.
Too late. The committee decides in the meeting.

D. Criteria evidence, risks, forecast, recommendation.
Gives governance exactly what it needs to decide.

THE SIGNAL

A phase gate is a decision. Present evidence against the criteria and a recommendation.

> A PMO asks each of four agile teams to report its velocity monthly, so that team productivity can be compared.
>
> The teams estimate in story points, and each team calibrated its points independently.

What should the project manager do?

A Explain that velocity is team-specific, and propose forecasts and outcome measures for comparison instead.

B Provide the velocities as requested, so the PMO can compare the teams.

C Refuse to report any agile metrics to the PMO.

D Ask all four teams to use the same story point scale so velocities can be compared.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Explain; offer forecasts and outcomes.

Meets the PMO's real need for visibility with measures that mean something.

B Provide velocity for comparison.

Comparisons are meaningless, and teams will start inflating points.

C Refuse.

Ignores a legitimate governance need for information.

D Standardise points.

Undermines each team's own estimating, and still invites gaming.

THE SIGNAL

Velocity is for a team's own planning, never a league table. Offer governance forecasts and outcomes.

> The project's cost forecast now shows a twelve percent overrun at completion, although spending to date is within budget.
>
> Before the board report, the finance director asks the project manager to show only spend to date, 'to avoid alarming anyone'.

What should the project manager do?

A Show only spend to date, since that figure is accurate.

B Report the forecast to the board without discussing it with the finance director.

C Discuss with the finance director why the forecast matters, then report it accurately with a recovery plan.

D Report the finance director's request to the ethics committee.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Spend to date only.

Every number true, the overall picture false. Omission misleads.

B Report it without discussion.

Right outcome, but skips the conversation and blindsides a colleague.

C Discuss, then report accurately with a plan.

Honest, collaborative, and gives the board something to act on.

D Report to the ethics committee.

Escalates before a single conversation. Too early.

THE SIGNAL

Leaving out a known forecast is misleading. Talk first, then report the truth, with options.

> A project manager used a generative AI tool to summarise team updates into the weekly sponsor report. The sponsor later points out that it gave the wrong date for a key milestone.
>
> The team's own updates had the correct date.

What should the project manager do?

A Stop using AI tools for any project reporting.

B Correct the error with the sponsor, and verify AI-drafted content against the source before sending.

C Explain to the sponsor that the AI tool made the mistake.

D Continue as before, since the error was minor.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Stop using AI.

Overcorrects. The tool saves time; the missing step was verification.

B Correct it; verify before sending.

Owns the error and fixes the process. Accountability stays with the PM.

C Blame the tool.

The PM sent the report. Accountability cannot be delegated to software.

D Carry on.

A wrong milestone date to a sponsor is not minor, and it will recur.

THE SIGNAL

AI can draft; the project manager is accountable. Verify against the source before anything goes out.

Honest, tailored, and built for a decision.

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